MEMBER GUIDES · C1B

For Partners and Families

Someone close to you has joined, or is thinking of joining, a Lodge in Hertfordshire. This is what it will mean for you: what he will do, what it costs, what you are welcome at, and who to speak to if you are ever concerned.

For	Partners, families and close friends of candidates and new members
Issue	Issue 1 (Draft for Review), October 2026 · Given with Considering Freemasonry (C1), before the application where possible

Freemasonry in Hertfordshire has a rule that we say out loud: Family, Work, Masonry, in that order, always. A Lodge that asks a member to put it ahead of his home has got it wrong, and we would want to know. This guide is written so that you know what is being asked of him, and of you, before it starts rather than after.

1 What he has joined

A Lodge is a group of men who meet a few times a year, usually in the evening, for a formal meeting followed by a dinner. The meetings have ceremonies that are centuries old and make up a kind of moral play: the three degrees he will go through in his first year or two are about honesty, learning and how to live a good life. They are entirely symbolic, safe and dignified. Between meetings there are rehearsals, social evenings, visits to other Lodges, and a great deal of fundraising for charity. Freemasons are not a religion, not a political organisation, and not a route to business advantage; a man who joins expecting any of those will be disappointed.

The secrets question

He can tell you almost everything. What Freemasons keep to themselves are the traditional ways they recognise one another and some of the words of the ceremonies, in the same way a surprise is kept for someone who has not yet had it. He cannot tell you those. He can tell you who was there, what was said at dinner, what he is learning, what it means to him, and anything that worries him. If he ever uses secrecy as a reason not to tell you where he was, that is him, not Freemasonry.

2 What it will ask of your household

Time	Most Lodges meet four to eight times a year, on a fixed weekday evening. He will be out from late afternoon to late evening. Add a rehearsal evening most weeks in the season, called the Lodge of Instruction, and the occasional visit to another Lodge. If he later takes an office, the rehearsals matter more and the learning takes time at home.
Money	A joining fee, an annual subscription, a dinner each meeting, and some regalia to buy. The Lodge will tell him the figures before he applies; if it has not, ask him to ask. There is a yearly charity collection too, always voluntary and private. Nobody should ever feel they cannot afford to stay, and the Lodge's Almoner is there precisely for the hard year.
Learning	In his first year he will learn a few short answers by heart for each ceremony, and may want to practise them aloud at home. He must not practise where you can hear the words; that is the one bit of Freemasonry you will have to let him keep. Everything else about it he can share.
The late nights	The dinner, with its toasts and speeches, can run late. Lodges vary. He will know the pattern after two meetings; ask him to tell you.

3 What you are welcome at

- **White Table evenings:** a dinner after a meeting to which partners and guests are invited. Many Lodges hold one or two a year.
- **Ladies Night (or the Master's dinner):** the Master's formal dinner each year, often the social highlight of the Lodge.
- **Social events:** quiz nights, walks, outings, the Christmas social; whatever your Lodge does. Partners are usually the point of them.

- **Provincial events:** carol services, family days, the Provincial church service, charity events across the county.
- **The Fleet House Light Blues Club:** the Province's club for newer members, with social events partners are often invited to (fhlbc.co.uk).

If you have never been invited to any of these, something has gone wrong, and the Lodge would want to know. Ask him to ask his mentor.

4 What he gets from it, and what you might

Friends he would not otherwise have met, of every age and background; something to learn that is not work; a reason to stand up and speak in front of people; and a place where he is expected to be kind. Partners often say the same three things: that he comes home in a better mood than he left, that the friends became theirs too, and that it took a year to understand why he liked it. Give it the year.

5 If you are ever concerned

Every Lodge has two people whose job includes you.

The Almoner	Looks after the welfare of members and their families: illness, bereavement, money, a hard time of any kind. He is discreet, he is used to being asked, and you may contact him directly. Ask your partner for his name, or the Lodge Secretary.
His mentor	Every new member in Hertfordshire has a Personal Mentor, a friend in the Lodge whose job is to help him settle in and enjoy it. If you feel the Lodge is asking too much, or he seems to be enjoying it less, the mentor is the person to tell, and he will want to hear it.
The Province	The Provincial Mentoring Team is there for members and their families: mentor@hertfordshirefreemasons.org.uk. Anything you raise is in confidence.

> **Family, Work, Masonry: in that order, always.** If his Lodge ever seems to have forgotten it, say so, to him first and then to his mentor. We mean it.

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